

JPL’s rough ride with layoffs

The lab has lost a fourth of its workers. Can it reclaim its high place in space sector?

By Noah Haggerty and Corinne Purtill

Designing the system that would bring a slice of Mars back to Earth at NASA’s Jet Propulsion Laboratory — the Southern California lab that pioneered American rocketry and the scientific exploration of our solar system — was her dream job.

As she worked toward degrees in mechanical engineering, she watched JPL launches and became enamored with the photos the lab took on Mars. She attended a JPL open house, which she said felt like “Disneyland.” She applied to work at JPL more than 60 times. When she finally got the job working on the Mars Sample Return Mission, she hoped to spend the rest of her career there.

But on Tuesday, she was one of the 550 employees the lab laid off — representing more than 10% of the workforce.

It was the fourth round of layoffs in two years at the lab, which has struggled since Congress pulled funding for its flagship Mars Sample Return mission because of a ballooning budget and timeline.

Morale has tanked amid reports of management problems. Staffers say they’re following budget discussions in the national news while hearing little from the lab’s leaders.

“There’s been this creeping dread in anticipation,” said the mechanical engineer, who spoke on condition of anonymity to share [See JPL, A9]

Traffic policing reform stuck in gridlock

By Libor Jany

A proposal to explore removing Los Angeles police officers from traffic enforcement is stuck in gridlock. Again.

The initiative to take the job of pulling over bad drivers away from cops is months behind schedule, frustrating reform advocates and some city leaders who argue that Los Angeles is missing an onramp toward the future of road safety.

Local officials first raised the prospect during the national reckoning on racial injustice that followed the police murder of George Floyd in 2020, but the plan has progressed in sluggish fits and starts since. Backers thought that they had scored an important victory with the release in May 2023 of a long-promised study mapping out how most enforcement could be done by unarmed civilian workers.

The City Council requested follow-up reports from various city departments to figure out how to do that and gave a three-month deadline. But more than a year later, most of the promised feasibility studies have yet to materialize.

“I’m very upset about the delay,” said council President Marqueece Harris [See Traffic, A8]



A WOUNDED child is rushed Sunday to Nasser Hospital after an Israeli bombardment in Khan Yunis, Gaza.

Batteries put a stop to blackouts

Investment in technology made difference in California’s grid

By Hayley Smith

For decades, rolling blackouts and urgent calls for energy conservation were part of life in California — a reluctant summer ritual almost as reliable as the heat waves that drove them. But the state has undergone a quiet shift in recent years, and the California Independent System Operator hasn’t issued a single one of those emergency pleas, known as Flex Alerts, since 2022.

Experts and officials say the Golden State has reached a turning point, reflecting years of investment in making its electrical grid stronger, cleaner and more dependable. Much of that is new battery energy storage, which captures and stores electricity for later use.

In fact, batteries have been transformative for California, state officials say. In late afternoon, when the sun stops hitting solar panels and people are home using electricity, batteries now push stored solar energy onto the grid. [See Batteries, A9]



BATTERY SOLAR energy storage units at the LADWP’s largest solar and battery plant, the Eland Solar and Storage Center in Kern County.

Inside the downfall of an exclusive Hollywood club

By Stacy Perman

When NeueHouse, the swanky members-only, co-working space debuted in Hollywood in the fall of 2015, two years after the brand launched its buzzy New York flagship, it arrived steeped in show business history and a wait list to get in.

The private club occupied the site of the fabled former CBS Studios on Sunset Boulevard that once hosted the radio shows of Orson Welles and was where the pilot of “I Love Lucy” was shot.

The location was the first of three impeccably hip spaces to unfurl across Los Angeles and it quickly became the nexus point for entertainment, media, art and technology, drawing members from the ranks of the

city’s screenwriters, producers and filmmakers. The Hollywood outpost became the scene of celebrity-filled parties, movie premieres, art exhibitions and concerts.

It was a fledgling empire of cool with ambitious plans to circle the globe.

Then reality hit. NeueHouse announced last month it was closing and filed for Chapter 7 bankruptcy.

“Although NeueHouse has created an extremely valuable business that is prized by members and event hosts, unfortunately, it has been burdened by legacy liabilities. Despite our best efforts to find a sustainable path forward — including exploring every possible solution to address these challenges — we have made

the very difficult decision to wind down the business and close NeueHouse,” the company said in a letter to its members.

What went wrong? Like other businesses, NeueHouse was hard hit by the pandemic, the dueling Hollywood labor strikes and the L.A. wildfires in January.

But NeueHouse was ultimately undone by problems of its own making, according to Times interviews with former employees, executives and members as well as a review of internal financial documents.

Even before the Hollywood unveiling, the venture was saddled with huge operating costs including expensive leases, according to former executives. Within a few years of opening, in [See NeueHouse, A10]



COUNTY Supervisor Lindsey Horvath speaks at an immigration rally in downtown L.A. in September.

Supervisor has ‘no plans’ for mayoral bid but doesn’t rule it out

By Julia Wick

Lindsey Horvath knew all the words to “Pink Pony Club.”

It was an overcast Sunday in June, the WeHo Pride parade was in full swing and the hit song about an iconic West Hollywood gay bar was blasting at full volume.

Clad in a sequined, rainbow muumuu, the county supervisor danced atop her pink pony-themed Pride float, swaying and mouthing the lyrics.

Five hours later, Horvath had traded her sequins and rainbow sneakers for a simple black dress and heels.

Now she sat on a wooden pew for evening Mass at her 121-year-old Catholic parish. She still knew all the words, albeit this time to a traditional hymn about the holiness of the Lord.

Horvath, 43, defies easy characterization. She is the first millennial

member of the county Board of Supervisors, a governing body that wields tremendous power despite remaining unknown to most Angelenos.

When elected in November 2022, she went from a relative unknown representing roughly 35,000 people as a West Hollywood City Council member to having more than 2 million constituents across a sweeping 431-square-mile district that sprawls from the Ventura County line down to Santa Monica, east to Hollywood and up through much of the San Fernando Valley.

As the county supervisor whose district contains Pacific Palisades, her public profile exploded in the wake of the devastating fires and as tensions between her and Mayor Karen Bass first became public.

In recent weeks, the Board of Supervisors has attracted public scrutiny over its decision to approve a [See Horvath, A8]



IAN WALTON Associated Press

VICTORY IN THE U.K.

Davante Adams and Matthew Stafford celebrate a score in Rams’ rout of Jacksonville. **SPORTS, D1**

Napoleonic jewels stolen from Louvre

The daytime heist took place within minutes, while visitors were inside the famed Paris museum. **WORLD, A3**

Shrapnel fell on CHP along I-5

The incident occurred after protective detail escorted Vice President Vance to Camp Pendleton. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Sunshine.
L.A. Basin: 82/60. **B6**



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